



DESTEMMED GRAPES GO INTO THE QVEVRI WITH SKINS, SEEDS AND PULP. AS FERMENTATION PRODUCES HEAT AND CARBON DIOXIDE, THE SOLIDS RISE TO THE TOP AND MUST BE PUSHED BACK WITH WOODEN STICKS EVERY THREE HOURS

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For its Georgian-style wines, destemmed grapes go into the vessel with skins, seeds and pulp. As fermentation produces heat and carbon dioxide, the solids rise to the top and must be pushed back down with wooden sticks every three hours. “Even at night we wake up and push the solids back in,” he says. This goes on for the first month. The *qvevri* is then sealed and left for another five months. “Georgian-style wine takes six months in total,” he explains.

Nothing is wasted. Once the wine is separated, the remaining grape material is used to make *chacha*, Georgia’s potent grape spirit. The *qvevri* are cleaned before being used again, and Tchitanava says a vessel can remain in service for

around 30 to 40 years.

Giuaani produces more white wines because Manavi’s climate and soils are particularly suited to white grapes. “Once the wine is removed from the *qvevri* after six months, depending upon the grape, some are straight away transferred into bottles, while some are aged in oak barrels and still others age in bottles,” continues Tchitanava.

He also says that ideally all Georgian-style wines need to be served at 13 to 16 degrees Celcius for white wines and up to 20 degrees Celcius for red wines to maintain the tannins and acidity levels. Wine’s place in Georgian life becomes clearest in places where you do not expect to find it at all. At Vardzia, the extraordinary medieval cave city cut into

a cliff in southern Georgia and associated with Queen Tamar, Georgia’s first female ruler, wine was part of the infrastructure. At its height, the complex contained dozens of wine cellars; Georgia’s official tourism portal records 28 cellars housing 235 *qvevri*. Monks prayed, lived, and stored wine within the same rock-cut world.

What began in clay jars millennia ago is now a global business. According to Georgia’s National Wine Agency, the country exported approximately 89.7 million litres of wine worth \$267.9 million in 2025, reaching 71 countries, including India, though in very small numbers.

So next time, may be give Bordeaux a pass and visit Georgia instead. **BT**